

PaisaPath

A beginner-friendly personal finance mentor for young adults entering financial independence. **What nine interviews taught us, and what we built because of it.**

● Harsh Patel ● Arvind S ● Soham Ghosh Team 20

The first paycheck arrives before the first financial skill

Three stages of handling money. Experience changed what went wrong. It did not fix it.

LEVEL 1 • PRE-EARNER

Riya, 19

"It is just a small payment... where did all my money go?"

9/9

had tried to track their spending and given up. Memory, UPI history, abandoned spreadsheets, even a self-built tracker

LEVEL 2 • CAUTIOUS FIRST EARNER

Samik, 23

"I want to manage my money wisely, but I'm still unsure I'm making the right decisions."

9/9

brought up trust or privacy on their own, before we asked

LEVEL 3 • EARLY INVESTOR

Anuj, 23

"I have started investing, but I still don't know whether I'm allocating the right way."

3/9

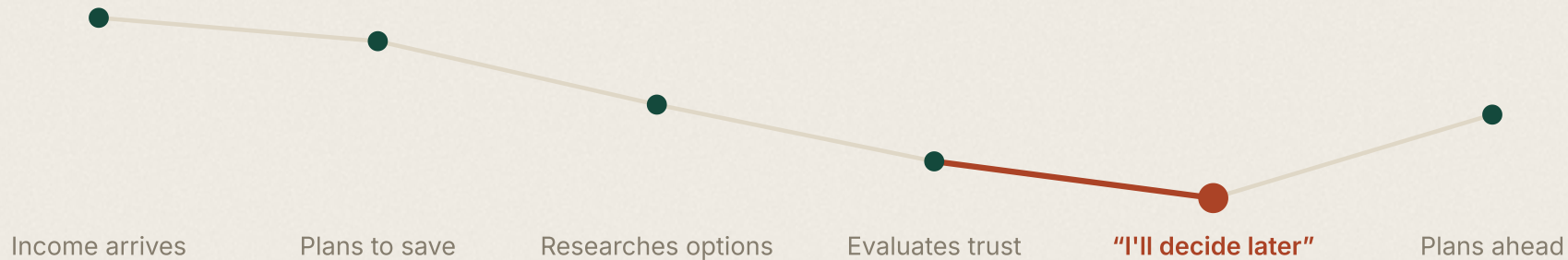
had already lost money on F&O, badly timed stocks or an over-invested stipend

0/9

could explain how to divide up a salary

Confidence collapses between researching and deciding

All nine journey maps came out the same shape, and they hit bottom in the same place.



Everyone stalls at the same point

They could follow the concepts. Choosing between a PPF, a fixed deposit and a mutual fund is where they stopped.

Uncertainty peaks when sources disagree

Parents, YouTube, ChatGPT, Gemini. "Different people give different advice. What do I do first?"

The lowest point is doing nothing

The money sits in the account and the confidence never builds. More experience does not flatten the curve.

Four gaps generate every symptom we observed

RC · 1

Guidance gap

No beginner-friendly, contextual help at the transition to independence. Education is generic and jargon-first; professional advice is expensive.

RC · 2

Structure gap

No planning tuned to income, goals and life stage. Our nine users needed four different budgeting approaches between them.

RC · 3

Confidence gap

No way to see the reasoning behind a suggestion, and no safe way to build judgement before real money is at stake. So the decision gets put off.

RC · 4

Trust gap

Data practices and commercial incentives are unclear. People cannot check whether the guidance is impartial, so they fall back on family advice.

What we kept coming back to: **these users already have plenty of information. What they are short of is confidence.** And trust decides whether they open the app at all.

Five ideas, four root causes

RC·2 · Structure gap
generic rules fit no one

Personalised budgeting & first-salary onboarding

- A questionnaire works out your profile, then splits your salary across essentials, an emergency fund, investments and spending. You drag it until it fits your life.

RC·2 · Structure gap
tracking dies on effort

Unified dashboard & automatic expense tracking

- Every account on one page. Expenses sort themselves, hidden charges get flagged, and you never type one in.

RC·3 · Confidence gap
“I’ll decide later”

“What if” decision simulator

- Type the question the way you would say it. “What if I invest ₹5,000 instead of spending it?” You see both futures side by side before you commit.

RC·1 · Guidance gap
help never arrives in time

Context-aware smart nudges

- They turn up when they are useful. Move money on the day your salary lands. Check a subscription that has crept up.

RC·1 · Guidance gap
learning never becomes action

Financial education, in context

- Every term gets explained inside the app, right where you are making the decision. A moderated peer community comes next.

“Won't AI become one more conflicting advisor?”

It cannot, because it never gets an opinion. That is built into the architecture.

WHAT WE DID NOT BUILD

- Another voice competing with parents, YouTube and ChatGPT
- Product picks out of a black box the user cannot check
- Anything tuned for engagement or commission

WHAT WE BUILT INSTEAD

- Deterministic rules produce every rupee on screen
- The model gets the finished figures and puts them into plain English. It is never asked to work one out
- Every recommendation shows its reasoning, its risk and two alternatives

WHY IT HOLDS

The maths lives in one file that contains no AI at all, so you can check any figure yourself. When the AI is unreachable every screen still works. A **Trust Centre** logs each AI call and what got sent. It weighs up the conflicting advice for the user, and has none of its own to add.

From “I’ll decide later”
to **one clear step**,
with the reason shown.

Ten screens are built and running, including the questionnaire, the mentor, and the simulator you can ask in plain English.

10

screens, built and running

6

financial profiles, from 22 questions

9

nudge triggers, each carrying its evidence

0

numbers written by an AI